The First Season Checklist

Regenerative Farming Philippines. From the family farm at Viking Farms PH, Calamba, Laguna.

This is the first season of the method, sized honestly: nine steps, in the order a transition actually happens on a tropical smallholding. Print it, pin it in the farm shed, and tick the boxes as the season runs. The full method is ten modules, taught at regenerativefarmingphilippines.com.

Before you touch anything

Step 1. Walk the land and change nothing, for the first weeks. Note where water stands after rain, where the soil is bare or crusted, what weeds grow where, what already grows well, and where the wind and sun hit hardest. Write it down. Every change made before observing is a guess about a farm you have not yet read.

Check when done: _____

The four moves that start everything

Step 2. Cover every patch of bare soil. Rice straw, crop residue, or a fast cover crop like munggo over every exposed patch. Bare soil loses moisture, biology, and topsoil every day it sits exposed. This is the cheapest, highest-impact action on the farm.

Check when done: _____

Step 3. Start one compost pile. About a cubic meter, from materials the farm already produces: straw layered with manure, watered as you build, turned when the center cools. One pile teaches the balance cheaply and is running before you need it.

Check when done: _____

Step 4. Start a biofertilizer brew. A container of fermented plant material and manure: kakawate or madre de cacao leaves, weeds, manure, molasses, water, weeks of fermentation. Small batch, from the farm's own boundaries.

Check when done: _____

One field, not the whole farm

Step 5. Pick one field and stop tilling it. The best-soiled or smallest field, covered first, is the test. Hand-open the planting holes, keep the mulch on, let the cover crop run between crops. The rest of the farm keeps its old routine while you learn what the transition looks like on your own ground. One field converts the farmer; the farmer converts the farm.

Check when done: _____

Step 6. Plant the cover on the gaps. Between cash crops, on paddies' edges, under trees: something growing everywhere the cash crop is not. This is the layer that keeps the biology fed and the weeds out.

Check when done: _____

The record that makes it provable

Step 7. Write down the four soil tests and the costs. A worm count, a jar test, a water infiltration test, and the smell and crumb of a handful of soil: one line each, per field, with the date. Input costs and harvest in the same notebook. This is the step that makes every other one provable, and it is skipped most often.

Check when done: _____

Step 8. Watch the wet season. If your first season includes the rains: the covered ground holds, the bare ground washes, and the difference is the most convincing argument on the farm. Check the drainage before the typhoons, not after.

Check when done: _____

Step 9. Read the results honestly. At season's end, the notebook tells you what moved: worms, water, weeds, costs. Mostly flat numbers after one season are normal. The direction is the result, and year two is where it compounds.

Check when done: _____

What to skip in year one

Big purchases. No equipment, no amendment supply, no brewing hardware beyond a container. The first season runs on things the farm already has.

The whole-farm conversion. Stopping tillage everywhere at once produces a weed flush and a workload shock. One field, done properly.

The premium market plan. Selling a premium crop requires a consistent harvest, which requires a running system, which takes seasons.

Chasing every practice at once. Two or three done properly beat nine attempted.

Judging by the first harvest. The first season's numbers are usually flat. The notebook holds the direction.

The season calendar for the tropics

When	What the farm does
Now	Cover the bare soil, whatever the season.
Before the wet season	Compost applied and mulched, covers established, drainage checked.
The wet season	Watch what the covered ground does that the bare ground does not.
The dry season	Mulch is the irrigation. Water in the early morning.
Season's end	Read the notebook honestly. The direction is the result.

The four no-lab soil tests, at a glance: worm count per spade (zero is a warning, eight or more is a working soil), the jar test for soil type, water infiltration time with an open can, and the smell and crumb of a handful from spade depth. Same spot, same season, every season.

Where this comes from

Every step in this checklist was farmed before it was written, at Viking Farms PH in Calamba, Laguna: three generations on the same land since 1940, the family farm kept while the land around it turned industrial. The straw that used to burn is now the mulch; the munggo on the paddies' edges is the cover layer; the notebook in the farmer's handwriting is the record the method is taught from.

The full method is taught in ten modules at regenerativefarmingphilippines.com, from reading your soil to making the farm pay. Join the Movement to get the next guides as they are finished, and the Founding Farmer rate when the course opens.

Join the Movement at regenerativefarmingphilippines.com

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